

Military Support Aircraft

While the wartime news was filled with tales of the fighters and bombers behind the front line (and sometimes ahead of it), a multitude of workhorse aircraft performed vital roles—from training pilots to transporting equipment, ground troops, and parachutists. In most cases, these were civilian models from the 1930s, usually strengthened and fitted with more powerful engines to withstand the rigours of military service.



▽ Douglas C-47 Skytrain 1940

Origin USA

Engine 2 x 1,200hp Pratt & Whitney R-1830-90C Twin Wasp air-cooled 14-cylinder radial

Top speed 224 mph (360 km/h)

The commercial DC-3 airliner entered military service as the much-loved C-47 Skytrain, or Dakota. More than 10,000 were built, with a cargo door and strengthened floor to carry troops and equipment.



△ Junkers Ju52 1940

Origin Germany

Engine 3 x 720hp BMW 132T air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 165 mph (265 km/h)

After both commercial and military roles before the war, the Ju52—with its distinctive corrugated metal skin—was a crucial transport aircraft for German forces in WWII despite its vulnerability to fighter attack.



△ Douglas C-54 Skymaster 1942

Origin USA

Engine 4 x 1,450hp Pratt & Whitney R-2000-9 Twin Wasp air-cooled 14-cylinder radial

Top speed 275 mph (442 km/h)

The Skymaster was the first aircraft type to carry the US President. It was a civilian DC-4 in military guise, used for many roles from transport and research to missile tracking and recovery. The C-54 was in service until 1975.



◁ Boeing Stearman Model 75 1940

Origin USA

Engine 220hp Continental 670 air-cooled 7-cylinder radial

Top speed 135 mph (217 km/h)

Flown solo from the rear seat, the remarkably sturdy Stearman first appeared in 1934 but performed well as a trainer for US and Canadian military pilots in WWII; over 8,000 were built.

▷ Miles M14 Magister 1940

Origin UK

Engine 130hp de Havilland Gipsy Major I air-cooled 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 132 mph (212 km/h)

Based on the civilian Hawk Trainer, the Magister first flew in 1937. It was the first monoplane designed as a trainer for the RAF, ideal for familiarizing pilots with the low-wing monoplane frontline aircraft then coming into service.



◁ Ryan PT-22 Recruit 1941

Origin USA

Engine 160hp Kinner R540 air-cooled 5-cylinder radial

Top speed 125 mph (200 km/h)

Claude Ryan's ST first flew in 1934. When war came, the military version—designated the PT—proved to be an ideal trainer for low-wing monoplanes and was also used for reconnaissance.

